over the transfer of power to elected representatives of the people as swiftly as possible. He insisted that he had no ambition to retain power, but in addition to his new title of chief martial law administrator, he took Ayub's title of president and remained Pakistan's top general.

Pakistan's first national elections were held on 7 December 1970, in the wake of a hurricane tidal wave that drowned a quarter of a million of East Pakistan's poorest people in the low-lying Delta of Bengal and left millions without food or shelter. This disaster was compounded by Yahya's failure to send immediate aid to the region, leaving Bengali peasants to die without food or medical supplies, which could have been flown in from West Pakistan and air-dropped to them. West Pakistan's indifference to the tragic plight of the country's eastern majority served only to further alienate Bengalis from Islamabad's ruling Punjabi and Pathan generals. When Yahya finally decided to view Bengal's devastation from his helicopter, he flew far too high to hear any of the screams or shouts of the hungry people, by then totally enraged at their West Pakistani masters, none of whom seemed to care about them, or understood their language, or tried to solve any of their problems.